

Slow-Cooker Coq au Vin

Family recipe, lightly refined | Serves 6 with rice

Allow about 25 minutes prep + 2½-3 hours on HIGH + up to 15 minutes finishing. Start checking at 2½ hours; allow longer if needed. Use a 5-6 qt slow cooker.

Ingredients

2 lb boneless, skinless chicken thighs, thawed
16 oz cremini mushrooms, thickly sliced
6 medium carrots, peeled, in ½-inch pieces
10 oz frozen pearl onions
4 garlic cloves, minced
1 envelope Lipton Beefy Onion Soup Mix

½ cup dry red wine
1 tsp each Worcestershire sauce and dried thyme
1 tsp cornstarch + 1 tsp cold water
1 tsp garlic powder
½ tsp ground black pepper; cooking spray as needed
Cooked rice, for serving
Optional: 1 tsp extra cornstarch + 1 tsp cold water

1. Load vegetables. Lightly spray the crock. Put carrots on the bottom, then add frozen pearl onions, mushrooms and garlic. Keep chicken refrigerated until ready to sear.

2. Brown chicken. Pat dry and season with the ½ tsp black pepper. Heat a lightly greased skillet over medium-high heat. Brown in uncrowded batches, about 2-3 minutes per side, until golden patches appear. Transfer straight to the vegetables; continue the recipe immediately.

3. Capture the browned bits. Briefly take the skillet off heat and add the measured ½ cup wine. Return to heat; scrape up brown bits for 30-60 seconds. Pour into the cooker, leaving any black, burned residue behind. Do not reduce the wine by half.

4. Season. Mix 1 tsp cornstarch with 1 tsp cold water until smooth. Add to the cooker with the 1 tsp Worcestershire, 1 tsp thyme, one envelope Lipton Beefy Onion Soup Mix and 1 tsp garlic powder. Distribute seasoning through the liquid as best you can. Cover and start HIGH immediately. The chicken and vegetables release liquid; no stock is needed by default.

5. Cook to tenderness. Begin checking at 2½ hours; the original range is 2½-3 hours. Several thighs must reach at least 165°F in the thickest part and separate easily with a fork; carrots must yield to a knife. Continue if necessary. If chicken finishes first, remove it and keep covered briefly while finishing carrots in a saucepan with some sauce.

6. Finish only as needed. If the sauce consistency suits you, leave it alone. If watery, remove chicken and vegetables and bring the liquid to a simmer in a saucepan. Mix the optional extra cornstarch and cold water; add gradually while stirring and simmer about 1 minute, until lightly coating. Avoid reducing an already salty sauce; loosen with a little water if needed.

7. Serve with rice. Taste chicken, sauce and rice together before adjusting seasoning. Return chicken and vegetables to hot sauce if separated. For a rice cooker, follow its matched rice-cup and water-line directions; start early enough for the full cycle, then Keep Warm until serving.

Leftovers: Refrigerate in shallow containers within 2 hours; use within 3-4 days and reheat to 165°F. Check soup-mix allergens. Cooking with wine does not make this alcohol-free.

Source: Jordan's "Coq au Vin Slow Cooker v2" export. Small changes: deglazing, smaller carrots, separate cold slurry, explicit doneness checks and optional sauce finish.